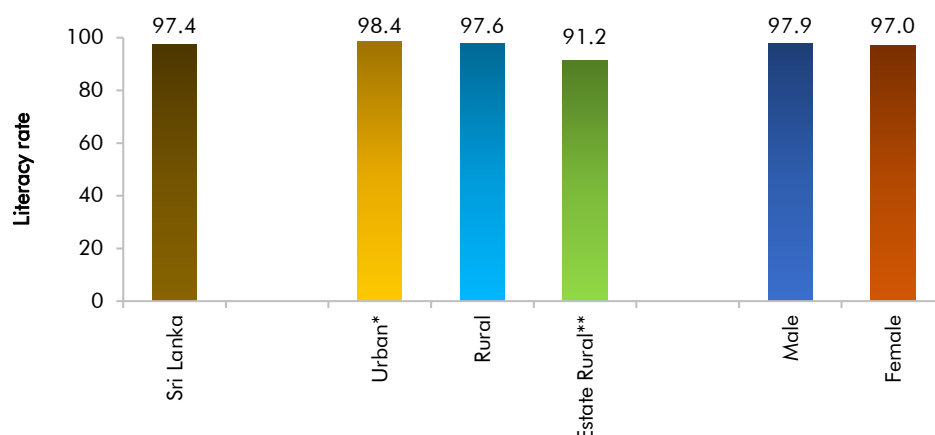


According to Table 7.8, the language literacy rate is calculated by identifying individuals aged 10 years and above with the ability to both read and write in at least one language. In reviewing the historical data from the 1881 census to the present, the language literacy rate in Sri Lanka has shown a consistent upward trend, reaching 97.4 percent in 2024. While the male literacy rate historically remains higher than that of females, the data for 2024 indicates that the female literacy rate has nearly converged with the male rate.



*Although the 2024 Census collected information separately as urban and estate urban, here the two categories are combined and shown as urban.

** The sector identified as 'Estate' in the 2012 Census corresponds to the 'Estate Rural' category in the 2024 Census.

Figure 7.2 : Language Literacy Rate by Sector and Sex, 2024

According to Figure 7.2, considering literacy by sector, the Estate Rural sector shows a lower language literacy rate (91.2%) relative to the other sectors.

Table 7.9 : Language Literacy Rate by Language and Age Group, 2024

Age Group	Language Literacy rate		
	Sinhala	Tamil	English
Sri Lanka	85.2	45.3	57.3
10-14	85.9	63.5	70.6
15-19	87.2	62.7	79.1
20-29	86.1	54.4	73.6
30-39	86.1	47.0	63.5
40-49	86.0	40.9	53.9
50-59	84.8	36.1	45.6
60 and above	82.3	30.8	35.0

The Table 7.9 presents language literacy rates in Sri Lanka by age group for Sinhala, Tamil, and English, revealing clear generational patterns in language proficiency. Overall, Sinhala literacy is the highest across all age groups, with a national rate of 85.2%, followed by English (57.3%) and Tamil (45.3%). Sinhala literacy remains relatively stable across age groups, with only a slight decline among older populations. In contrast, Tamil and English literacy rates show more variation by age. Younger age groups, particularly those aged 10–14 and 15–19, report significantly higher literacy in both Tamil and English compared to older groups. This suggests improved access to education and greater emphasis on second-language learning in recent years. This is further illustrated in Figure 7.3.